

## Test Layer 4: Unified Action Point System

Version: 2026-04-25 framework. To be finalised after Layers 1–3 are tested.

**Framework — to be finalised after Layers 1–3 are tested.** Incorporates whichever Layer 1–3 changes were accepted. Sections marked [FROM LAYER X] indicate where those results plug in.

**What we're testing:** Does collapsing two turn phases into a single Action Point pool create better decisions and reduce cognitive overhead?

**Hypothesis:** When moving and casting draw from the same resource (AP), every action involves an opportunity cost trade-off. This creates more “agonising choices” and makes spells feel more central — they compete directly with movement rather than living in a separate phase.

**Watch for:**

- Do turns feel more fluid (one decision space) or more overwhelming (too many options)?
- Do players spread AP across pieces or focus on one?
- Does anyone rush a piece across the board using all 3 AP for movement?
- Are “pure caster” turns (0 movement, 3 skills) viable and interesting?
- Is 3 AP the right number?

### Goal

Capture the opponent's **King**. The game ends immediately when a King is removed from the board.

**Draw conditions:**

- No piece has been captured for 10 consecutive full rounds.
- Only the two Kings remain on the board.

### Components

- **Board:** [FROM LAYER results — likely 10×10, no terrain.]
- **Per player:** [Current piece count — likely 5 Champions + 6 Guards + 1 King unless changed.]
- **Shared:** Skill tokens/cards, Rune tokens, Round tracker.

### Setup

[Same as current after Layer 1–3 results.]

### **CHANGED: Turn Structure — Unified Action Points**

**Old system (two phases):**

1. Movement Phase: 2 Move Slots
2. Action Phase: N Skill Slots

**New system (unified):**

Each turn you receive **3 Action Points (AP)**. You may spend each AP on one of:

- **Move:** Move one piece (by its speed).
- **Skill:** Activate one equipped skill on a Champion or King (pay Rune cost).
- **Attack:** Perform a Standard Attack (move onto enemy tile, deal 2 DMG).

You may use 0, 1, 2, or 3 AP. Unused AP are lost — no banking.

**The concept of Skill Slots is removed.** Each skill activation costs 1 AP + its Rune cost. The former Skill Slot progression (was +1 every 10 rounds) is replaced by the flat 3 AP per turn. If the game needs late-game escalation, consider increasing AP to 4 after Round 15 (test separately).

### Piece Freedom — Test All Four Models

| Model    | Rule                                                                                           | Rationale                                                                            |
|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>A</b> | Each piece can use at most 1 skill per turn. Moving the same piece multiple times is allowed.  | Spreads skill usage. Doesn't prevent movement rushing.                               |
| <b>B</b> | Each piece can receive at most 1 AP per turn.                                                  | Forces spreading across army. Most restrictive — every AP goes to a different piece. |
| <b>C</b> | Uncapped normally. When $\leq 2$ pieces remain, that player's pieces can receive unlimited AP. | Standard play spreads actions. Desperation mode enables comeback.                    |
| <b>D</b> | A single piece can receive at most 2 AP per turn. The 3rd AP must go to a different piece.     | Allows Move + Skill on one piece but prevents full-AP rushing. Moderate.             |

**Recommended test order:** Start with Model D (moderate, intuitive). If too restrictive → test A. If rushing is a problem → test B. Test C as a variant on whichever base model works.

## Combat

*[FROM LAYERS 2–3: Use 3 HP system if accepted. Use simplified Bodyguard if accepted.]*

**Standard Attack:** Spend 1 AP to move your piece onto an enemy-occupied tile. Deal 2 DMG. If target removed, occupy tile. If target survives, your piece stops on the tile before.

## Health & Armor

**All pieces have 2 HP:** Normal → Injured → Removed.

| State   | HP | Effect                                                     |
|---------|----|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Normal  | 2  | No penalty                                                 |
| Injured | 1  | Speed capped at 1. Skill Range –1 (affects Range 2+ only). |
| Removed | 0  | Piece leaves the board permanently.                        |

### Damage:

- 1 DMG to Normal → Injured.
- 1 DMG to Injured → Removed.
- 2 DMG to Normal → Removed instantly (Injured state is skipped).

**Armor:** Max 3 points per piece. Each absorbs 1 DMG, then destroyed. Resolves before HP damage. Does not prevent Injured status.

## Resource Economy

*[FROM LAYER 1 results.]*

## Skill System

**Skill Path:** Skills travel in a **straight line** (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal) from the caster, like a chess Queen.

**Blocking:** The Skill Path is blocked by **all pieces** — ally and opponent alike. The skill cannot reach past the first piece in its path.

**Range:** The distance in tiles along the Skill Path from caster to target. Range is measured as:

- Range 0 = self (caster's own tile)
- Range 1 = adjacent tile along Skill Path
- Range 2 = 2 tiles away along Skill Path (etc.)

**Default Range = 2.** Unless a skill specifies otherwise.

**Injured Range penalty:** Injured pieces have Skill Range –1. This only affects skills with Range 2 or higher — adjacent (Range 1) and self (Range 0) always work regardless of Injured status.

**Skills that move pieces do not deal damage.** Movement-via-skill (Quick Dash, Shadow Shift, Retreat Plan) does not count as a Standard Attack and deals no damage on arrival.

**A Champion may use its skills multiple times in the same turn** if Skill Slots are available — including the same skill twice.

All skills cost 1 Skill Slot unless noted otherwise.

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### Progression

**AP per turn:**

| Round                          | AP per turn |
|--------------------------------|-------------|
| All rounds                     | 3           |
| After Round 15 (optional test) | 4           |

## Skill Reference

|                                                                                     | Cat.   | Name             | Cost | Effect                                                                                                                             |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|------------------|------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|    | Strike | Lance Thrust     | 2    | Target within Range-1 takes 1 DMG                                                                                                  |
|    | Strike | Hook Pull        | 3    | Target takes 1 DMG, pulled 1 tile toward caster along Skill Path                                                                   |
|    | Strike | Armor Breaker    | 2    | Remove 1 Armor from target                                                                                                         |
|    | Strike | Rune Theft       | 3    | Target takes 1 DMG. Steal 1 Rune from opponent.                                                                                    |
|    | Strike | Blade Tempest    | 4    | Target takes 1 DMG. All pieces adjacent to the target are pushed 1 tile away from the target. The attacker/caster is not affected. |
|    | Shield | Rust Shield      | 2    | Self: gain +1 Armor                                                                                                                |
|    | Shield | Field Medic      | 3    | Remove Injured from one adjacent ally                                                                                              |
|    | Shield | Armorsmith       | 3    | Adjacent ally gains +1 Armor                                                                                                       |
|    | Move   | Quick Dash       | 3    | Self: move up to 2 tiles along Skill Path                                                                                          |
|    | Move   | Air Blast        | 2    | Push target enemy 1 tile directly away from caster                                                                                 |
|    | Move   | Precision Thrust | 3    | Push target enemy 1 tile in any direction (caster chooses). <b>Range+1 (Range 3 at default).</b>                                   |
|    | Move   | Shadow Shift     | 4    | Swap position with an allied piece. Requires unobstructed Skill Path.                                                              |
|   | Move   | Retreat Plan     | 4    | Self: move along Skill Path to land adjacent to one of your Guards. <b>Range+1.</b>                                                |
|  | Mystic | Focus Strike     | 1    | The next skill used by <b>any of your pieces</b> this turn gains +1 Range.                                                         |
|  | Mystic | Blade Call       | 3    | One Strike skill used by <b>any of your pieces</b> this turn deals +1 DMG. Fixed cost: 3 Runes.                                    |

## Post-Game Questions

1. Did turns feel more fluid or more overwhelming?
2. How often did you want a 4th AP? How often did you have AP left over?
3. Did you ever rush a single piece across the board? Was it effective or punished?
4. Did "Move + Skill on the same piece" feel like a natural combo?
5. Which piece freedom model did you test? How did it feel?
6. Do you miss the two-phase structure? Or is unified AP better?
7. Should AP increase in later rounds, or is 3 flat the right number?

## Layer 5: Board Size & Piece Count (Placeholder)

Cannot be fully specified until Layer 4 results are in. The AP budget and piece count interact too heavily.

**Direction:** Shrink to 8×8. Reduce pieces (3 Champions + 3 Guards + 1 King is the proposal, but the exact ratio depends on how AP and HP systems interact).

### Key questions for Layer 5:

- Is 8×8 with 14 pieces the right density?
- Is 3:3 Champion:Guard ratio correct? (King makes 4 skill-carriers vs 3 Guards — asymmetric)
- Does starting placement matter significantly on 8×8? Should it become a strategic choice?
- Is no terrain the right call, or does the smaller board need terrain to create interesting zones?

*Will be written as a full rule sheet after Layers 1–4 are resolved.*